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Criticism and conflict have great value

Your critic should live right next door.

Sant Tukaram

Our traditional self-image of India consists of seeing us as a healthy liberal democracy. There are, however, many disturbing features which have crept in gradually. As an example, we may think that India has a free press, but India is now ranked 140th out of 180 countries on press freedom, by Reporters Without Borders. As a consequence, there is much less criticism of the establishment than is required.

As policymakers, we tend to develop a point of view. We should, however, be humble. We are not omniscient, and we are frequently wrong. It is wise to listen to our critics as they are likely to often be right.

Good for fairness, good for self-interest

A healthy democracy is one in which diverse points of view are able to engage in civil discussions, engage in give-and-take, and search for common ground. Critics see the world from diverse points of view. All these points of view are legitimate elements of the democratic process of negotiation and compromise.